

Appendix D: Async Spec Planning

The Agora names the form and its sharpest risk. This is the full treatment, for the teams the Curse of Sisyphus was about, the ones the problem damages most: distributed, different timezones, permanently async. They deserve more than a synchronous prescription.

The session becomes a review request on the spec. The draft opens. Comments come in. The what, the why, and the not-building get challenged asynchronously. The merge condition is when the team has converged, meaning the concerns have been addressed and the understanding is shared.

The phases map directly. The draft carries intent, constraints, and non-goals before it opens. The comment thread is the challenge phase, and silence is still not an answer; every named reviewer responds or the spec doesn't merge. The consent round is the approval set, with objections as blocking comments. The timebox becomes a deadline: two working days, not two weeks.

The room's mechanics have to be replaced, and one of them can't be. In the room, an idea reaches the document only by passing through someone else's hands: the driver types what the group says, so no framing reaches the document unfiltered. Async has no filter. One person holds the pen, their framing is the document, and everyone else reacts to it, which is the handed-spec problem the Agora warns about, built into the form's first move. The thread's challenge compensates only partly; that is the honest cost of working apart.

What can be replaced: the read-back becomes the revision note, where the owner writes what changed under challenge and why before merging. A spec that merges unchanged is the async version of a room that nodded. And the lead's clock becomes the merge owner, rotating like the room's lead: someone whose job this round is to call convergence at the deadline, not to win the thread.

The mitigation for the risk the Agora names is minimum viable context, applied to the spec proposal itself. A proposal rich enough that a reviewer cannot respond meaningfully without actually thinking about it. One that surfaces the assumptions, names the edge cases, explains the

reasoning behind the decisions, demanding engagement rather than permitting rubber-stamping. A spec drafted by an agent and reviewed by an agent merges without anyone having understood it; the review request is the session, and if no human thinks in it, it didn't happen.

The same culture requirement applies. The async version needs people to actually comment, actually raise the concern, actually say "I don't think this covers the edge case where X," rather than approving because nobody wanted to slow things down or because an AI generated a plausible-sounding approval. A blocking comment can be performed just like a consent round can; the form guarantees a response, not a thought.

The test for whether it worked is not whether the review request merged; it is the same test the room uses: whether the team could explain the decisions without the document. The fuller async build, as it evolves, lives at leftoftheloop.dev.